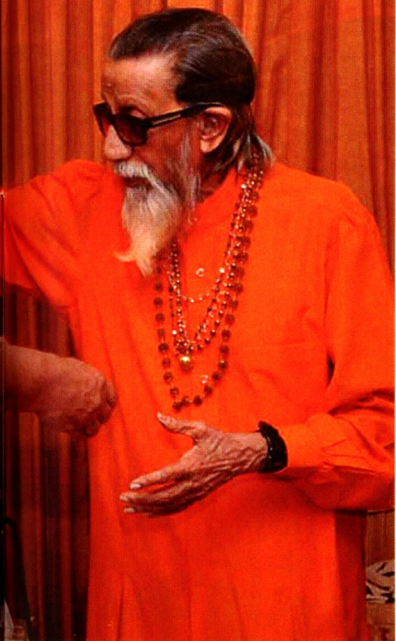


HAJESH WAARDKAR

FRIENDS FOREVER: Pawar (L) gears up to ally with Thackeray



Amravati district of Vidarbha region, helping NCP get a foothold in the territory, which is traditionally a Congress stronghold. Old timers from Pawar's era no longer get shocked by his flip-flops as he's known to break bread with a sworn enemy if it is a means to capture power. Says Hussain Dalwai, Maharashtra Pradesh Congress Committee spokesperson, "He is known to be unpredictable." The new alliance in rural pockets like Amravati will give both the Sena and NCP an opportunity to strengthen their base in rural Maharashtra.

Vidarbha is not only politically sensitive due to farmers' suicides, but

also politically significant as it sends 11 MPs to the Lok Sabha and 66 MLAs to the state Assembly. The Congress got routed in its bastion in the 2004 general elections, when it got only one out of 11 Lok Sabha seats. Veteran Congress leaders blame this debacle on Pawar, who was allegedly advising Congress President Sonia Gandhi on the choice of candidates. They allege that Pawar advised New Delhi to field reserved candidates even in Vidarbha's open seats, which caused a rebellion against the Congress in its safe seats.

While the Congress headquarters have made their displeasure with Pawar apparent by warning him of the "dangers of riding on two horses" at the state-level, the Congress is borrowing a page out of NCP's books to counter the Maratha leader. In western Maharashtra's Sangli district, the Congress has joined hands with independents to keep Pawar's party out.

If Pawar is not eroding the strength of his rivals by instigating rebellions, he is keeping his party's doors open to defectors from rival factions. Within months of the NCP-Sena combine staking claim on Pune corporation, Congress corporator Suman Chimate resigned citing harassment by MLA Vinayak Nimhan as a reason. Nimhan is a close aide of Narayan Rane, revenue minister and erstwhile Shiv Sainik. While the Congress alleges NCP's hand in this, NCP Pune unit chief Anil Bhosale has denied that his party played any role in the matter, even as it gave Chimate a ticket to contest from the same ward.

With a measly strength of 11 MPs, Pawar's party may not be a national force to reckon with but he continues to

be the kingmaker in Maharashtra. The Congress, for its part, has tried very hard to create a leader of the stature of Pawar but has not succeeded. Rane had shown much promise, but even his aura is fading in the face of Pawar's realpolitik. After taking six MLAs to the Congress, Rane had given the party a greater tally than NCP in the Assembly but the defeat of Sena defector Subodh Mohite on a Congress ticket from the Ramtek Lok Sabha seat in April has shown the lack of leadership within the Congress's state unit.

While his 1999 rebellion is the one most talked about, Pawar bashers say he's always instigated rebellions to prevent the Congress from becoming powerful, irrespective of whether he is inside or outside the party. His peers cite the 1995 state elections as an example when the party failed to give tickets to his loyalists. This prompted a mass rebellion and 45 independent candidates contested the elections. Says Atul

Bhatkarkar, general secretary of BJP, "It is widely believed that Pawar had encouraged these independent candidates to rebel."

With general elections and assembly elections just round the corner, Pawar may yet again spark another round of rebellions within the Congress both in the state and Centre to weaken the party, which is a lot more dependent on outsiders now than it was earlier. With the growing closeness of Sena and NCP, the Congress is preparing itself for a triangular contest in Maharashtra on one hand and on the other, the looming threat of a third front led by Pawar at the Centre. ■

Leading rebellions is Pawar's forte, whether it is splitting and forming a new party or inciting a revolt elsewhere.

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